

Northwind Home: keeping the agent trustworthy after go-live

Domain FDE Pre-Work Deep Track · Blue Data Consulting · Customer experience, supply chain and finance

The business

The customer operations agent is live. It handles complaints, returns and refunds for all three back-office teams, and answers their questions from company records and policies. Every week it touches about 400 complaints and 2,600 returns. The launch went well. The harder question is what happens next, because **the agent can change without anyone touching its code**.

A week in production

Day	What happened	What the business noticed
Monday	The model provider released an update under the same model name	Nothing. Answers read a little differently
Tuesday	A team lead tidied the wording of the agent's instructions and removed a sentence that looked redundant	Two customers were told their refund was on its way before Billing had agreed it
Wednesday	Billing updated its refund policy document to say 50 pounds, ahead of a decision that was never made	Staff were told the limit is 50 pounds, while the payment system still stops at 25
Thursday	The refund ledger stopped responding for two hours	Replies stayed polite. Nobody saw that no refunds were being checked

No code changed all week. Every problem came from a change someone was allowed to make, in a place each team owns.

Where it goes wrong today

- **Nobody can say which version answered.** When a customer complains about Tuesday's promise, there is no way to tell what the agent was told on Tuesday.
- **Changes arrive from every team.** Customer experience owns the wording, Finance owns the refund policy, supply chain owns the returns rules, and the provider owns the model. Each change is reasonable on its own.
- **Polite answers hide failures.** On Thursday the agent recovered gracefully, so the outage looked like normal service.
- **There is no way back.** Undoing Wednesday's change means finding the old document, if anyone kept it.
- **Incidents are argued, not recorded.** Without evidence of what happened, each one becomes a debate about whose change caused it.

Who is affected

Stakeholder	What they need
Customers	Promises that are true, and the same answer on Friday as on Monday
Complaints, returns and billing leads	To change their own wording and policies safely, and know when a change went wrong
Head of operations	To know within minutes that the agent has degraded, and to put it back within minutes
Risk and compliance	For any answer, the exact instructions, policies and model that produced it
The on-call engineer	Evidence, not opinions: what changed, when, and what it broke

The business question

How do we know what the agent must keep doing, notice quickly when it stops, put it back safely, and learn from every incident, when anyone can change its behaviour without touching the code?

How this is tackled in practice, by operating the agent in Google ADK, is in [usecase1_day7.pdf](#). All names, figures and data are made up.